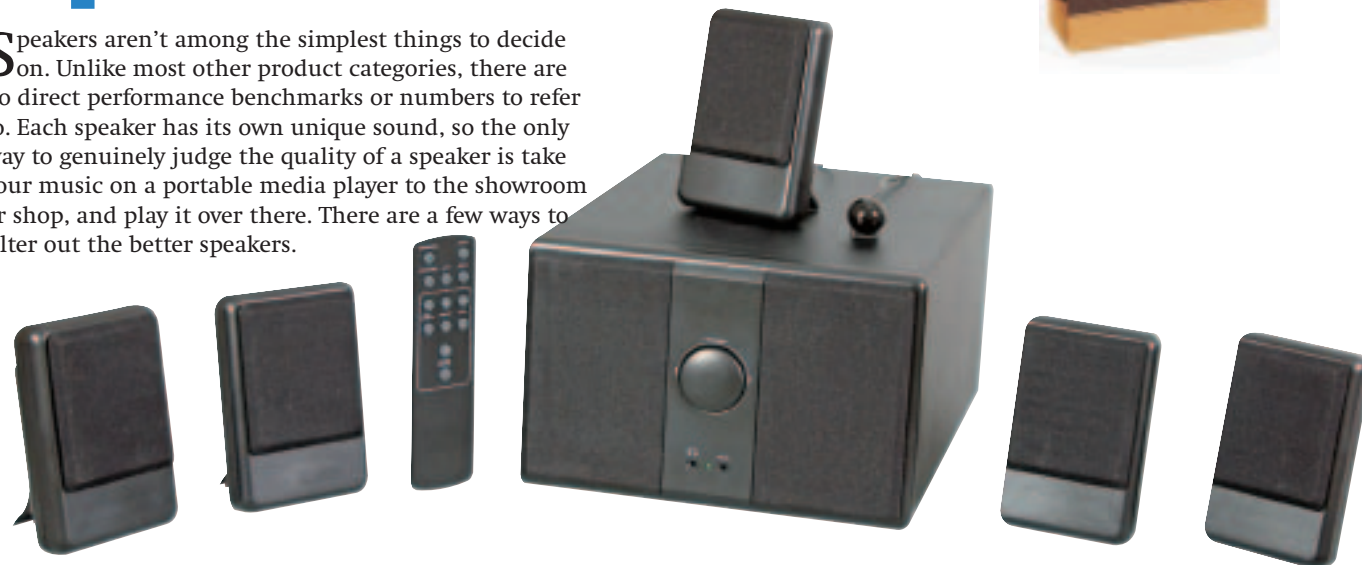


Speakers

Speakers aren't among the simplest things to decide on. Unlike most other product categories, there are no direct performance benchmarks or numbers to refer to. Each speaker has its own unique sound, so the only way to genuinely judge the quality of a speaker is take your music on a portable media player to the showroom or shop, and play it over there. There are a few ways to filter out the better speakers.



What Do You Need?

Everyone needs speakers or at least needs to own a set. Speakers are typically meant for listening to music and watching movies. Gaming is another growing form of entertainment that's best experienced with a good set of speakers. Surround sound speakers — those that come with four or five satellite speakers and a subwoofer are best suited for movie watchers and gamers.

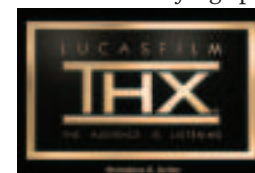


Those who want to listen to just music should stick to 2.1 speakers. The music we listen to is recorded in two channels, so 4.1 and 5.1 sound systems will be a waste.



Standards And Certifications

Although this isn't the best way to judge the quality of speakers, it's a must while buying speakers.



Speakers with any kind of certification tend to be the safer bet, as they are only certified if they follow set design criteria or their sound meets a specific standard. In this process, however, you will automatically miss out on good models from the lesser known brands.

Cables

Speakers come with cables, but the quality of cables is a concern with some speakers. They are too thin, flimsy and are bound to break if tugged on. Look for thick and well insulated cables. Some speakers even come with gold-plated connectors.



Drivers

Quality is contributed to by the components in the speaker itself. The driver size can help you get an idea of size. Well-known speaker manufacturers sport their driver sizes. Look for large drivers in your speakers to ensure powerful and good quality sound. Some speakers use a single, full-range speaker, or multiple smaller drivers with each one dedicated to a range of sound frequencies. Here's where the range of frequencies is important. Speakers should go as low as 20 Hz and as high as 20,000 Hz. Look for speakers that support this range or even better.



Connectivity

Speakers should allow the user to connect all kinds of audio sources. A 3.5-mm jack is a must for desktop speakers that are to be used with a computer. If a 3.5-mm jack isn't supported, then be sure to get 3.5-mm to RCA connector converters.



Remote Control

Like a TV, speakers are meant to be kept slightly away and it's bound to get annoying when you have to reach for your computer to increase the volume. A remote is one of those things that skip people's minds. Look for a speaker that comes with a remote control to make things a little simpler. Look for remotes that come with controls for bass and treble as well as the volume control and obviously a mute button. If remotes aren't available at least find speakers that come with a wired console to control the speakers.



Wired-remote



Wireless Remote

Design

Speakers most likely end up in the living room or right next to the computer. Design, then becomes one of the most important factors of a purchasing decision. They should have an appealing design, and at the same time, should be built robustly. The sturdiness of the speakers also says things about the quality of the speaker — the heavier the speaker, the better chances of it being good.



next to the screen, but the rear speakers need special arrangement. If the speakers don't have stands, look for provision for mounting the speakers on the wall or another stand. If they don't, then you have go through the trouble of buying some separately or making some.

Stands

Make sure that the stands or base of the speakers is sturdy enough and won't topple over easily. Some speakers even come with stands. These are good, especially, if you are looking for surround sound speakers. The front speakers often sit comfortably on the table

The Body

The body of the speaker is also important. Avoid plastic bodies. Instead, look for thick heavy wooden cases. The tone of your speaker's output is highly influenced by the kind of materials used for the frame. Again, weight can help filter out the poor quality speakers.